CASSIAN CREED CASE FILE · SOURCED · VICTIM-FIRST

The Trail: The Murder of Rachel Morin

A free, sourced dossier — the people first, a primary-source timeline, a disclosed analytical lens, and the safety lessons.

VICTIM	Rachel Morin — mother of five, Harford County, Maryland. Killed August 5, 2023, on the Ma & Pa Heritage Trail in Bel Air.
IDENTIFIED	Victor Martinez-Hernandez — linked through DNA and investigative genetic genealogy; arrested in Tulsa, Oklahoma, June 2024.
STATUS	Convicted on all four counts (April 2025). Sentenced August 11, 2025 to two consecutive life terms without parole, plus 40 years. He stated an intent to appeal; the conviction stands.
HOW IT TURNED	Crime-scene DNA tied the same offender to an earlier home-invasion assault, then genetic genealogy and a nationwide search narrowed to a name.

The people, first

Rachel Morin was thirty-seven, a mother of five, and a fixture of her stretch of Harford County, Maryland. On the warm evening of August 5, 2023, she texted a friend and set out for a run on the Ma & Pa Heritage Trail, a wooded rail-trail she knew well. She did not come home. Her body was found the next day off the trail. What followed consumed a community — not because of the man who took her, but because of who she was to the people who loved her. This case file keeps her at the center, where she belongs, and treats the man who harmed her as the record requires: named only where the facts are settled, never glorified.

A primary-source timeline

- **August 5, 2023** — Rachel Morin goes for an evening run on the Ma & Pa Trail in Bel Air and is reported missing that night.
- **August 6, 2023** — Her body is recovered near the trail; the Harford County Sheriff's Office opens a homicide investigation.
- **Late 2023** — Crime-scene DNA is linked to an offender connected to a March 2023 home-invasion assault in Los Angeles County, suggesting the same man had crossed the country.
- **June 2024** — Investigators, aided by genetic genealogy and a national manhunt, arrest Victor Martinez-Hernandez in Tulsa, Oklahoma.
- **April 2025** — After a nine-day trial, a jury convicts him on all four counts: first-degree murder, first-degree rape, a third-degree sexual offense, and kidnapping.
- **August 11, 2025** — He is sentenced to two consecutive life terms without the possibility of parole, plus 40 years. He states he intends to appeal; the conviction stands.

The A.I. AL lens — disclosed

Every Cassian Creed case file carries one honest, labeled section on where a disciplined analytical lens — we call it A.I. AL — could and could not have helped. It is a lens, never the author, never the narrator, and it never claims a solve. Here, the decisive moves belonged to people and to a lab: the DNA match that connected two crimes a continent apart, the genealogy that turned a profile into a family tree, and the investigators who ran down the name. An analytical lens can sharpen how those threads are weighed and sequenced; it cannot stand in for the warrant, the swab, or the arrest. We say so plainly, because the alternative — implying a machine cracked the case — would be a lie, and the victims deserve better than a lie.

What this case teaches — stay safe

Rachel Morin did everything ordinary and right. The lesson here is never that a victim should have done more; it is what the rest of us can carry forward. Share your route and a return time with someone you trust. Keep a phone reachable. Trust the instinct that says a place feels wrong. And if you or someone you love is in danger or in crisis, reach out — the resources below are free and confidential.

Want the full account?

This dossier is the short version. **The Trail: The Murder of Rachel Morin** is the complete, book-length case file — the full timeline, the records, the trial, and the people at the center — for **$5.99**. Or take both live titles in the Case Files Collection (The Trail + No Accident) for **$8.99**. And the free Sunday newsletter sends the next case file straight to you.

Read The Trail — $5.99 cassiancreed.com/books	**The free newsletter** cassiancreed.com/free-dossier

If you need support. 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (call or text 988) · RAINN 1-800-656-HOPE (4673). Sourced from the public record and contemporary reporting; legal status current as of June 2026.

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